reason for the person to join this march, the ultimate purpose was the same for all of us—to save India from the fires of hatred.

Every day was a new experience from then on. As we moved ahead, people from every part of the country came to participate in the Yatra. People from across communities, religions and languages joined in. Some came to see us, others came to walk with us; some shared their grief with us, while others shared their hope; some lightened our hearts with laughter on difficult days and others reminded us of the cause that we were walking and fighting for. There were also those who could not physically participate, yet ensured that their support was counted in through other means. And just like this, we kept moving ahead. It was us and the Yatra, with each other and in each other at every juncture.

Wherever the Yatra passed through, we as yatris experienced India in its totality—its people, societies, economic shifts, cultural exuberance, religious piety and glorious landscapes. The people, in turn, observed and experienced the Yatra. The yatris themselves were almost nomads, as each evening we entered a new campsite, meticulously planned ahead by our amazing organizing team. However, by the time we would settle in, the site would be demolished again and re-established in another part. Even though it was well equipped with all basic necessities, living in this environment still brought its own challenges for each of us. Waking up every day, getting ready, hoisting the flag, singing prayers, having breakfast (and on some days even skipping it) and starting the padyatra—this was our routine for five long months.

As the Yatra progressed across India, the layers of the yatris were laid bare as well. For the first time in my political life, I realized how the process of the Yatra brought out the inner values and truest behaviours of those travelling together. When you live with someone for months together, you get to see the inner character of that person. The gap between what someone says and what they practise becomes easily visible. I came to the realization that if one wished to truly understand someone, they had to undertake a yatra together. In political life, where pretence, deceit and fakery are commonplace, a yatra offers one a chance to witness the reality